LESSON 1: INTRODUCTION TO CURRICULUM

1.1 Introduction

In this first lesson, we want to introduce ourselves to the key terms and concepts in curriculum. As you may be aware, every discipline has its own terms and concepts that are specific to that discipline. For example, in the different areas of specializations such as engineering, medicine and so on, there are terms and concepts that are specific to that area. It is important to note that Throughout our teaching experiences, we have found that an understanding of the basic principles behind the subject and their applications increases the students' motivation for the subject. We therefore introduce you to the terms and concepts upon which the study of curriculum is based and encourage you to engage in in-depth discussions of these concepts and theories in curriculum. The purpose of this first lesson is to enable you understand to various terms and concepts in the field of curriculum. Welcome to our first lesson.

1.2 Lesson learning outcomes

By the end of this first lesson, you should be able to:

1.2.1 Define the terms education, curriculum and syllabus

1.2.2 Explain the term curriculum development

1.2.3 Define the term curriculum design

1.2.4 Define the term learning experiences

1.2.1 Definition of education, curriculum and syllabus

Education is a term that everyone has heard about and a term that we constantly refer to. The term education is a term that everybody is has been defined differently by different as acquisition of knowledge, skills and positive attitude. This process of acquisition of the knowledge, skills and positive attitude should however be systematic and not haphazard. The term education can therefore be defined as a systematic process through which a child or an adult acquires knowledge, skills, positive attitude, and experiences that make them functional members of the society

The word curriculum on the other hand is derived from the Latin *currere* meaning 'to run'. The term curriculum is often defined as the courses offered by a school though it is rarely used in such a general sense in schools. Curriculum includes all those activities which are utilized by the school to attend the aims of education. Curriculum is all the experiences a learner has under the guidance of the school. Curriculum refers to the lessons and academic content taught in a school or in a specific course or program. Curricula usually define the learning that is expected to take place during a course or programme of study in terms of the acquisition of knowledge, experience, skills and attitudes, they should specify the main teaching, learning and assessment methods and provide an indication of the learning resources required to support the effective delivery of the course.

Pratt (1980) defines curriculum as a written document that systematically describes goals planned, objectives, content, learning activities, evaluation procedures and so forth.

Hass (1987) provides a broader definition, stating that a curriculum includes "all of the experiences that individual learners have in a program of education whose purpose is to achieve broad goals and related specific objectives, which is planned in terms of a framework of theory and research or past and present professional practice" (p.5).

Grundy (1987) defines curriculum as a program of activities (by teachers and pupils) designed so that pupils will attain so far as possible certain educational and other schooling ends or objectives.

Goodlad and Su (1992) define curriculum as a plan that consists of learning opportunities for a specific time frame and place, a tool that aims to bring about behavior changes in students as a result of planned activities and includes all learning experiences received by students with the guidance of the school.

According to English (2000), "curriculum is any document that exists in a school that defines the work of teachers by identifying the content to be taught and the methods to be used" (p.2)

Wojtczak (2002) defines curriculum as an educational plan that points out the goals and objectives to be achieved, topics to be covered and methods to be used for learning, teaching and evaluation.

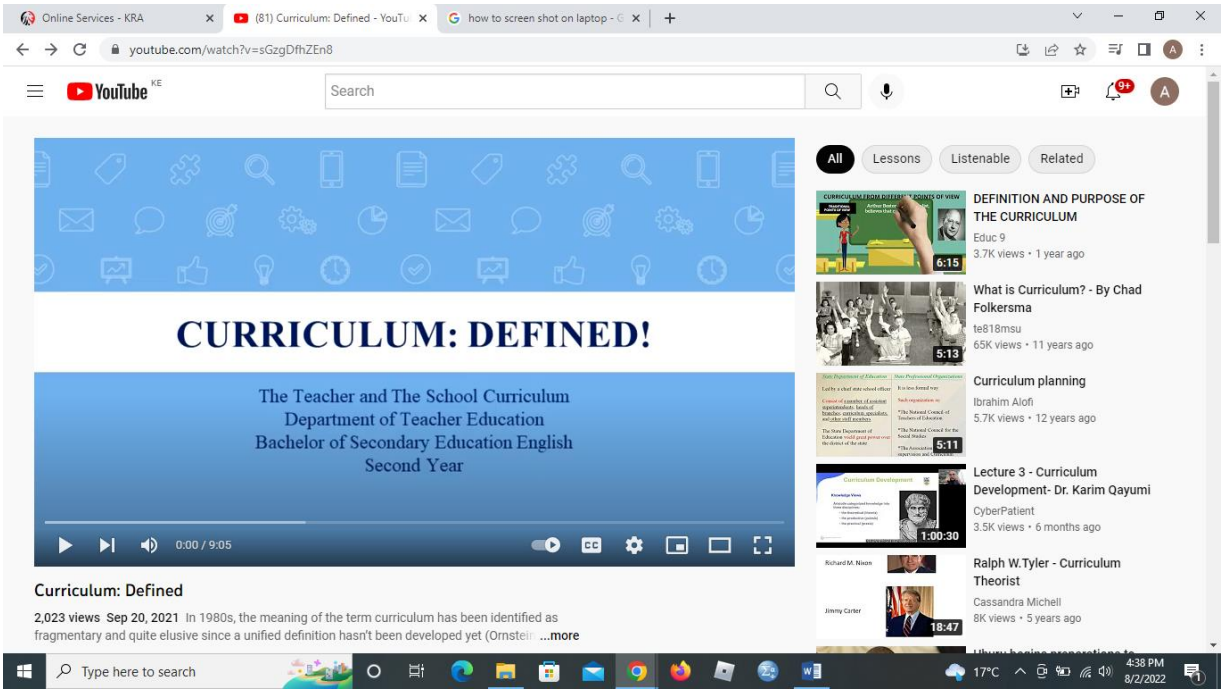
Syllabus

More often, the term curriculum is usually confused with the term syllabus. It is important to state that curriculum is more than a syllabus. Having said that, let is now define the term syllabus. The term syllabus describes the content of a programme and can be seen as one part of a curriculum. Syllabus is the subjects in a course of study or teaching. A syllabus is an outline for a course that you are either taking or teaching. The syllabus is derived from the curriculum.

E-tivity

Listen to the following video and define curriculum in your own words

https://youtu.be/sGzgDfhZEn8



1.2.2 Curriculum development

The term curriculum development is defined as planned, a purposeful, progressive, and systematic process to create positive improvements in the educational system. It is as the step-by-step process used to create positive improvements in courses offered by a school, college or university.

1.2.3 Curriculum design

Curriculum design refers to the structure or organization of the curriculum. It is the purposeful, deliberate, and systematic organization of curriculum. The term curriculum design refers the planning period when instructors organize the instructional units for their course. Curriculum design involves planning activities, readings, lessons, and assessments that achieve educational goals. Curriculum design focuses on the creation of the overall course blueprint, mapping content to learning objectives, including how to develop a course outline and build the course

1.2.4 Learning experiences

Learning experience refers to any interaction, course, program, or other experience in which learning takes place, whether it occurs in traditional academic settings (schools, classrooms) or nontraditional settings (outside-of-school locations, outdoor environments), or whether it includes traditional educational interactions (students learning from teachers and professors) or nontraditional interactions.

1.3 Assessment questions

1. In your own words, distinguish between Education, curriculum and syllabus
2. What is the difference between curriculum development and curriculum design?
3. What are learning experiences?

1.4 References

https://youtu.be/sGzgDfhZEn8

https://educarepk.com/the-definition-of-curriculum.html?_

Shiundu, J., & Omulando, S. (1992). Curriculum: Theory and practice in Kenya. Nairobi: Oxford University Press

Kridel, C. (Ed.). (2010). *Encyclopedia of curriculum studies* (Vol. 1). Sage.